

Iraq



Area 168,754 sq miles
(437,072 sq km)
Population 32.7 million
Capital Baghdad
Currency New Iraqi dinar
Official languages Arabic
and Kurdish
Life expectancy 59 years

Iraq is an oil-rich nation located in Western Asia. In 2003, a US-led invasion ended the dictatorial rule of Saddam Hussein. In 2005, elections were held, which established democracy in Iraq. However, sectarian violence continues to affect Iraq's stability.

Turkmenistan



Area 188,456 sq miles
(488,100 sq km)
Population 5.1 million
Capital Ashgabat
Currency Manat
Official language Turkmen
Life expectancy 63 years

A former Soviet republic, Turkmenistan became independent in 1991. The Turkmen were nomadic tribal people. Tribal units remain strong, and the largest groups are the Tekke in the center, the Ersary in the east, and the Yomud in the west. Turkmenistan is largely a Sunni Muslim country, with a small minority of Russian Orthodox Christians.

Kyrgyzstan



Area 76,641 sq miles
(198,500 sq km)
Population 5.4 million
Capital Bishkek
Currency Som
Official languages Kyrgyz
and Russian
Life expectancy 68 years

Kyrgyzstan, officially the Kyrgyz Republic, is a small, mountainous nation in Central Asia. The Kyrgyz are a Turkic-speaking people, closely related to the neighboring Kazakhs. Their traditional nomadic lifestyle was forcibly changed when they were under Soviet rule, though many cultural practices linger, especially in rural areas.



▲ **PICKLING SPICES**
Some of the spices used in Iran for pickling are dried aniseeds, coriander, ginger, golpar, powdered limes, cinnamon, and cumin.

Uzbekistan



Area 172,742 sq miles
(447,400 sq km)
Population 27.8 million
Capital Tashkent
Currency Soti
Official language Uzbek
Life expectancy 67 years

Uzbekistan became a sovereign state in 1991, after splitting from the USSR. It is the most populous country in Central Asia and contains the ancient cities of Samarkand, Bukhara (Bukhoro), Khiva, and Tashkent, which once flourished as trade centers. Uzbekistan is one of the world's main cotton producers and is rich in natural resources.

Tajikistan



Area 55,251 sq miles
(143,100 sq km)
Population 7 million
Capital Dushanbe
Currency Somoni
Official language Tajik
Life expectancy 67 years

Tajikistan lies landlocked on the western slopes of the Pamir Mountains in Central Asia. Its language and traditions are similar to those of Iran. Ethnic Tajiks make up about 80 percent of the population. Uzbeks constitute the second-largest group, at around 15 percent. Tajikistan is one of Central Asia's poorest nations.

Iran



Area 636,296 sq miles
(1,648,000 sq km)
Population 74.8 million
Capital Tehran
Currency Iranian rial
Official language Farsi
Life expectancy 71 years

Iran, formerly Persia, became an Islamic republic in 1979 when Ayatollah Khomeini overthrew the Shah's monarchy. Religious clerics, called *mullahs*, possess great political and moral authority. Iran has the world's second-largest oil and gas reserves.

Kazakhstan



Area 1,049,155 sq miles
(2,717,300 sq km)
Population 16.2 million
Capital Astana
Currency Tenge
Official language Kazakh
Life expectancy 66 years

Kazakhstan borders Russia to the north and China to the east. It was the last Soviet republic to declare its independence, in 1991. Kazakhstan is among the world's top 20 oil producers. It is ethnically diverse—Kazakhs make up more than half the population, and nearly a third is Russian, with a minority of Germans, Uzbeks, and Ukrainians.

Afghanistan



Area 250,000 sq miles
(647,500 sq km)
Population 32.4 million
Capital Kabul
Currency Afghanis
Official languages Pashtu
and Dari
Life expectancy 44 years

Afghanistan is landlocked in Central Asia, and much of its terrain is inaccessible. Its political system, economy, and infrastructure have been devastated by decades of armed conflict. The Islamist Taliban militia came to power in 1996. In 2001, US-led attacks overthrew the regime, though the Taliban is trying to make a comeback.

